

Chapter 126-1

Winter arrived in Haizhou City without a sound.

Not a single snowfall came—only the heavy rain that night later turned into sleet. The next morning, when people woke up and went to work, they discovered a thin layer of white ice crystals on the ground.

Before the sun could even come out, it had already been washed away by the overnight rainwater.

Then the temperature dropped below zero, cold enough to make people shiver.

The wind hadn't even blown many times.

Counting back, that should have been the biggest rainstorm of the year, as well as the most chaotic wind. That night, thick fog rose on the national highway, and a chain rear-end collision occurred, becoming hot news in Haizhou City.

The next day, many people were discussing that night's storm. Some people's cars were of poor quality and had actually been dented by the hail.

Everyone said the weather that day was absurdly excessive.

The entire Haizhou City was swept into winter by the temperature.

Inside the hospital, it was lunch break time.

Zhao Xuning had just finished her morning shift handover, went home to sleep, and hurriedly took a shower before coming back—her hair was still half-dry.

She first went to Gu Junru's office.

Gu Junru was watering the green plants on the windowsill. The indoor plants received much better treatment than those outside—they were in a greenhouse environment with someone watering them on schedule. It would be hard for them not to flourish.

Seeing her enter, Gu Junru put down the watering can, simply washed her hands, and then put on her white coat, buttoning it while asking: "Why didn't you rest a bit longer?"

"I've rested enough," Zhao Xuning said.

Gu Junru fell silent.

Ever since the kidnapping case happened that day, Zhao Xuning had been appearing at the hospital for increasingly longer periods.

She had personally performed Liang Shi's surgery—four stitches at the collarbone and three stitches on the arm. Both wounds had exposed bone; the wounds were very deep.

In the abandoned factory, Zhao Xuning had only given Liang Shi simple treatment. After sending her to the hospital, she was urgently wheeled into the operating room, and Zhao Xuning changed into surgical attire and directly performed the suturing.

Excessive blood loss required emergency transfusion, but Liang Shi's blood type was Type S-O blood, which was also a relatively rare type. The hospital only had two bags, which were all used on her, but it still wasn't enough.

In the end, a nurse with the same blood type helped with an emergency blood transfusion.

The wounds were sutured properly and everything was handled well, but Liang Shi just wouldn't wake up.

Actually, neither of those two wounds were fatal injuries—one was on the arm and one on the collarbone, and no major blood vessels had been cut. Yet during the resuscitation that day, Liang Shi's heart stopped multiple times.

It was beyond Zhao Xuning's range of understanding—cardiac arrest with absolutely no identifiable cause.

Before they could even use a pacemaker, her heartbeat returned to normal on its own.

It was like someone standing at the edge of a cliff, their body constantly leaning out and pulling back, completely inexplicable by common sense.

It had startled all the doctors and nurses in the operating room.

Fortunately, after the surgery ended, everything returned to normal, and Liang Shi's body was steadily recovering—except she still hadn't woken up.

This was the third day of her coma.

It was the second day since Xu Qingzhu had woken up.

Liang Shi's situation was special, and Xu Qingzhu's situation was also special.

That day in the abandoned factory, Gu Junru couldn't calm Xu Qingzhu's emotions. No matter what she said, Xu Qingzhu couldn't hear it—she had already retreated into her own little world.

Left with no choice, Gu Junru could only give her a sedative injection.

Chapter 126-2

After one injection of sedative, under normal circumstances, she would wake up after sleeping through the night, but Xu Qingzhu remained unconscious for two days.

A full two days.

She had only woken up last night. After waking up, she was like a wooden, expressionless Barbie doll—her complexion pale as paper, sitting on the hospital bed, her thin frame looking as if a gust of wind could blow her away.

She seemed soulless, not knowing what she was doing, nor knowing where she was.

She didn't ask, didn't speak, and ignored everyone.

Gu Junru tried to communicate with her, but was also shut out.

She was like a solitary island, drifting to the middle of the sea, refusing anyone's approach.

After waking up, she hadn't slept again. She had kept her eyes open from last night until now—the corners of her eyes were red from staying up, yet she still sat there woodenly. When food was brought to her, she would eat; when she needed to use the bathroom, she would go by herself.

Last night at midnight, she couldn't open the bathroom door and got frustrated with herself, squatting on the ground crying in anger.

When Gu Junru heard the sound and entered the room, she found her squatting with her arms wrapped around herself. Even hearing the door open, she had no reaction—just softly sobbing.

In that instant, Gu Junru thought she had returned to over a decade ago, when she first met Xu Qingzhu.

Back then, Xu Qingzhu's condition was also very bad, not much different from now.

Back then, she had to be in the light—she couldn't be in any dark environment at all. At night, the incandescent lamp in her room would be exceptionally bright, so bright it hurt her eyes, but she had to have it that way.

The light was even so glaring that she couldn't sleep.

There couldn't be a single sound near her ears—not even footsteps—otherwise she would curl up on the bed like a bird startled by the mere twang of a bow¹, trembling all over. Even if the sound later disappeared and never came back, she could still tremble the entire night.

Gu Junru had spent a very long time helping her emerge from that state.

The treatment process lasted seven years before she became somewhat like a normal child, helping her reconstruct her worldview.

The treatment of psychological illnesses is an extraordinarily long process.

Almost no one can claim to be one hundred percent cured.

These years, Xu Qingzhu had simply not been triggered again and had avoided those enclosed spaces that frightened her, so she had never relapsed.

But who would have thought...

Gu Junru squatted down and patted her shoulder, gently asking: "Qingzhu, what's wrong?"

Unexpectedly, Xu Qingzhu didn't speak to her. She just turned around again and started working on the door handle. Her hands turning the handle had been rubbed red, yet she still refused to give up.

Gu Junru had wanted to watch her overcome the difficulty on her own, but in the end, she helped open it out of heartache.

Afterward, Xu Qingzhu finished using the bathroom and lay back on the bed, keeping her eyes open, just like that with her eyes open until dawn.

In the entire day, she had only spoken two words in a daze: "Jiejie..."²

Both the Xu family and the Su family learned about what happened to her that day. Su Zhe came to the hospital to visit once, didn't linger around, and went directly to help handle matters on Chen Liuying's side—finding lawyers and collecting evidence, wanting to get Chen Liuying sentenced to life imprisonment.

Meanwhile, Xu Guangyao returned to the company during these days while Xu Qingzhu was incapacitated. He left all the important documents for Xu Qingzhu to review while he handled some trivial matters.

Su Yao and Sheng Linlang met for the first time since Su Yao returned to the country, yet never imagined it would be under such circumstances—with the unconscious Xu Qingzhu still lying on the hospital bed, the two of them looked at each other, wordless.

Afterward, it was Sheng Linlang who spoke first: "Yaoyao, have you been doing well these years?"

That affectionate "Yaoyao," though still carrying some caution, instantly pulled the scene back to those years.

Su Yao's eyes immediately brimmed with tears. "Jie, I've been doing quite well."

Su Yao didn't blame Sheng Linlang either. She held Xu Qingzhu's ice-cold hand, trying to warm it up.

Meanwhile, Sheng Linlang tucked in the corners of Xu Qingzhu's blanket.

But Xu Qingzhu lying on the bed was in a coma and knew nothing of this.

1. "A bird startled by the mere twang of a bow" (驚弓之鳥) - A Chinese idiom referring to someone who has been so traumatized by a frightening experience that they become extremely nervous and jumpy at the slightest thing, like a bird that was once shot at and now panics at just the sound of a bowstring. ↵
2. "Jiejie" (姐姐) - Chinese for "older sister." In this context, Xu Qingzhu is calling out for Liang Shi, whom she called "jiejie" since childhood. ↵

Chapter 126-3

Visitors came and went from Xu Qingzhu's hospital room.

In comparison, Liang Shi's side was very empty. Apart from Zhao Xuning, her attending physician, who kept watch over her, no one else had come to visit.

Oh, Su Yao and Sheng Linlang had visited Liang Shi a few times out of "loving the house and its crow"¹.

After visiting, they even asked Zhao Xuning, "Is her condition serious?"

Upon learning that her injuries were sustained because of Xu Qingzhu, both mothers showed expressions of sympathy.

Su Yao also asked Sheng Linlang, "Jie, what foods help generate blood?"

Sheng Linlang didn't know either and tentatively asked back: "Pig blood? You are what you eat."²

Standing to the side, Zhao Xuning's mouth twitched at what she heard. Afraid they would do something useless, she had to remind them: "After the patient wakes up, I'll give you a list of foods for dietary supplementation, along with eating schedules. Right now nothing can be used—we don't even know when she'll wake up."

Only then did Su Yao and Sheng Linlang give up.

However, unlike Sheng Linlang, Su Yao knew nothing about the Liang family. Having stayed abroad for so long, she was no longer familiar with these families in their social circle. Even after seeing Zhao Xuning, she thought for a long time before tentatively asking, "Are you Wang Ye's daughter?"

Wang Ye was Zhao Xuning's mother.

Zhao Xuning nodded in confirmation.

Only then did Su Yao say: "Your mother and I had a pretty good relationship before. We were in consecutive grades in high school."

Zhao Xuning responded politely with a few words. Afterward, Su Yao quietly asked her: "What about Liang Shi's family? Why haven't I seen them? Does she have no other relatives?"

Zhao Xuning paused, momentarily unsure how to explain it to her, so she could only tell a well-intentioned lie: "Liang Shi's family doesn't know she's injured yet. Because her injuries weren't considered particularly serious that day, no critical condition notice was issued. Besides, I'm here—she won't have any major problems."

After saying this, she added: "She has relatives, they're just quite busy. She also doesn't really want to trouble her relatives, so I didn't notify them."

Su Yao responded with a dazed "okay."

On the other hand, Sheng Yu would come after school, staying in the hospital room until evening.

When Su Yao saw she was tired and wanted to take her away, she said while yawning: "I'm not tired. I want to keep jiejie company."

In the end, she stubbornly fell asleep lying on the edge of Xu Qingzhu's hospital bed.

After Xu Qingzhu woke up, people came and went from the hospital room again—one group would come and another would leave. There was always someone in the room, but Xu Qingzhu didn't talk to anyone.

She was only slightly different with Su Yao.

As if she still remembered that Su Yao's mental condition wasn't very good, she would reluctantly say to Su Yao: "You should go back."

Her tone was careful and cautious, as if afraid of hurting her.

When Su Yao stared at her with tear-filled eyes and tears fell down, Xu Qingzhu just sat there frowning, looking somewhat impatient.

This relapse was much more severe than before. Dr. Gu readjusted the medication for Xu Qingzhu to take, along with some scientific treatment methods.

Zhao Xuning came to find Gu Junru because she wanted to take Xu Qingzhu to see Liang Shi.

It was Zhao Xuning who proposed this method, because Gu Junru had said that Xu Qingzhu rarely spoke, and once she did, the two words she said most were—jiejie.

And they all knew that the word "jiejie" referred to Liang Shi.

In that kidnapping case, Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu had depended on each other for survival.

Afterward, Liang Shi's temperament changed drastically, while Xu Qingzhu was left with PTSD³.

What they experienced during that time, only they themselves knew.

And the grown-up Xu Qingzhu had voluntarily married Liang Shi. Even knowing that her reputation was bad, she had still plunged in without hesitation.

It was just unexpected that things remained the same but people had changed⁴.

The only method Zhao Xuning could think of to stimulate Xu Qingzhu was to take her to see Liang Shi.

But this method carried risks, so Dr. Gu had to come along.

When Zhao Xuning and Gu Junru arrived at the hospital room, Xu Qingzhu was lying on the bed with her eyes open, staring at the ceiling. Her eyes were lifeless, her hands resting on her abdomen—no one knew what she was thinking.

Zhao Xuning stepped forward and spoke coldly, "Xu Qingzhu."

Xu Qingzhu didn't move.

Zhao Xuning paused and said: "Do you want to go see Liang Shi?"

Only upon hearing the name "Liang Shi" did Xu Qingzhu have a slight reaction. Her neck turned to look at Zhao Xuning. Those clear eyes appeared lifeless and dazed, without any of their usual spirit.

Seeing it was effective, Zhao Xuning continued: "Your wife, the jiejie who was kidnapped together with you when you were little, the jiejie you've always been thinking about—Liang Shi."

The hospital room was completely silent. Both Gu Junru and Zhao Xuning were nervous, unsure whether this method would work on Xu Qingzhu.

Back then, Gu Junru had used traditional therapy to help Xu Qingzhu, trying countless methods. It took nearly two months just to get Xu Qingzhu to speak to her.

Building a bridge of communication between the two of them had taken nearly a year.

But at this moment, after a long silence, a glimmer of light flickered in Xu Qingzhu's eyes, and she lightly pressed her lips together.

She had small physical movements, which meant she was thinking.

A few seconds later, Xu Qingzhu sat up, her hands propping herself up on the hospital bed. A hint of color appeared on that face so pale it was nearly transparent, and her cool, clear voice rang out in the hospital room.

Xu Qingzhu asked: "Where is she?"

After a moment, Xu Qingzhu said: "I want to see her."

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1. "Loving the house and its crow" (愛屋及烏) - A Chinese idiom meaning to love someone so much that you extend that love to everything associated with them. In this case, because they love Xu Qingzhu, they also care about Liang Shi who is important to her. ↵
 2. "You are what you eat" (吃什麼補什麼) - A traditional Chinese belief that eating certain animal parts will nourish the corresponding parts of your own body. Here, the suggestion is that eating pig blood would help replenish blood. ↵
 3. PTSD - Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder, referred to in the original as 創傷應激障礙. ↵
 4. "Things remained the same but people had changed" (物是人非) - A Chinese idiom expressing that while external circumstances may appear unchanged, the people involved have fundamentally changed. Here it refers to how although Xu Qingzhu married the same person she knew from childhood, Liang Shi was no longer the original person (the current Liang Shi is the transmigrated soul). ↵

Chapter 126-4

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Her entire being was plummeting at high speed, her soul losing its weight.

After falling for who knows how long, she landed in a vast expanse of thick fog.

Clusters upon clusters of fog shrouded her on all sides—she couldn't see anything.

Voices kept coming through.

"Jiejie, let's get out of here."

"Wuwuwu, jiejie, I'm scared."

"Jiejie, stop smiling, they'll hit you."

"Jiejie, do you have any wishes?"

"Jiejie, look! Fireflies!"

"I heard that if you make a wish on fireflies, the wish will come true. Jiejie, what did you wish for?"

"I hope to have lots and lots of love."

"..."

A young child's voice rang in her ears, and all those memories carried by the wind returned to her mind.

In that abandoned factory, a group of children were trapped there. The kidnappers called their parents demanding ransom, saying they would kill them if no ransom was paid.

The kidnappers sat together in twos and threes, smoking and drinking while fantasizing about the future.

Because she smiled too much, they knocked out her front teeth.

They were a bunch of inhuman things.

But even more inhuman than them was—after she was kidnapped and they called her parents demanding ransom—Qiu Zimin's ice-cold voice.

Qiu Zimin said: "Kill her then."

Those three words left an indelible shadow in the young child's heart.

Many memories came flooding in. The scenes were still vivid, except the scenes of being kidnapped were covered with a layer of gray—as if memories she never wanted to recall in this lifetime were being dredged up again.

In her memories there were also green grass and fresh flowers, laughter and joy, but more of it was darkness and fear.

Soon, the thick fog enveloped her again.

Two little girls huddled together for warmth in the abandoned factory. She had learned from Qi Jiao to always carry White Rabbit milk candies¹ with her, and she secretly slipped one to the little sister in the factory.

She led the little sister to escape together. They held hands, and the wind blew up their hair and skirts.

She comforted the little sister: "Don't be afraid, I'm here."

Actually, she herself was scared to death too.

They ran until they were gasping for breath, but didn't dare stop—looking for all the world like they were fleeing for their lives.

The memories from before age eight that had been sealed away were almost all remembered now.

The dust-covered past was taken out again, surprising Liang Shi.

Liang Shi suddenly thought of Xu Qingzhu's strange way of breaking up the word, "Jiejie"

She was the only one who had that strange pause when calling "jiejie."

Yet it was also exceptionally familiar and pleasant to hear.

Because that was how she called it when she was little, calling it again and again.

The thick fog was about to swallow her whole. Everything in sight was white, as if a heavy snow had fallen.

"Liang Shi... A-Shi..."

Someone in the distance was calling her name. Liang Shi wanted to open her mouth to respond, but found she couldn't speak at all.

She opened her mouth, but her throat felt like it was stuffed with cotton—she couldn't say anything.

Liang Shi could only keep walking forward, walking toward the direction of the voice.

But ahead was a vast expanse of fog. She couldn't see the path, and the voice seemed to come from near and far.

Which way should she go?

Liang Shi felt so tired.

She wanted to find Xu Qingzhu. Xu Qingzhu's shrill voice from that night still echoed in her ears—she didn't know how she was doing now.

Once this ended, she would have her own body.

She could stand in front of Xu Qingzhu and say openly and honestly: "I am me."

She could embrace and kiss without any burden, and tell her: "I remember you now, little Zhuzi."

Liang Shi had so many, many things she wanted to say to her.

She walked forward aimlessly, her stamina giving out, and collapsed in the vast fog.

As her consciousness scattered, that familiar eerie mechanical voice came again: 【Bzzt... bzzt...】

It was still that sound like an electric drill, making Liang Shi's scalp tingle, wishing she could smash her own head open.

The static sound only lasted a few seconds, but for Liang Shi it was extreme torture.

【Host... program... error... bzzt...】

The mechanical voice was intermittent, saying a few words before crashing again.

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1. White Rabbit milk candies (大白兔奶糖) - A famous Chinese milk candy brand that has been popular since the 1940s. The candies are known for their creamy, milky taste and their distinctive white wrapping with a blue and red rabbit logo. They are a nostalgic treat for many Chinese people and are often associated with childhood memories. ↵

Chapter 126-5

Liang Shi's consciousness gradually dissipated.

In the distance, a ray of light shone through, dispersing the fog before her eyes. Liang Shi struggled to stand up again. Her legs were trembling, yet she still walked forward with unwavering determination.

She seemed to hear Xu Qingzhu calling her.

She walked toward the direction of the light.

The thick fog dispersed, and she heard: "Liang Shi."

"A-Shi."

"Liang Shi."

Too many voices were echoing in her ears. Liang Shi's body was heavy, her eyelids were heavy, her footsteps were heavy—every step she took was laborious.

Yet every step she took was to get closer to Xu Qingzhu.

She thought, she mustn't let Xu Qingzhu be frightened.

Her little Zhuzi would definitely cry if she saw her injured.

The little sister from childhood, and her now—both were adorable little princesses¹.

How could she bear to make her little princess cry?

Xu Qingzhu, wait for me.

Liang Shi walked forward with all her might. Finally, the clouds parted and the fog dispersed. Amidst those repeated calls of "Liang Shi," she opened her eyes.

What met her eyes was pristine white, and the surroundings were filled with the smell of disinfectant—pungent to the nose.

Her eyes hadn't yet adjusted to the glaring light. After opening her eyes, she instinctively closed them again.

Then from beside her came a voice: "Liang Shi?"

It was a very familiar voice.

Immediately followed by another sentence: "Liang-jie, you're awake?"

Then came the sobbing she had heard countless times: "Wuwuwu."

Following that was a stern rebuke: "Stop crying, hurry and call the doctor! Arrange a full examination for Liang Shi."

Such scenes had often occurred in the past few years, but in the past one hundred days, Liang Shi had never heard them.

She thought all of this was far away from her now, but unexpectedly, hearing it again still made her eyes grow warm.

But...

Liang Shi forced herself to adjust to the light. She turned her head and saw the person before her.

She licked her dry lips, her voice hoarse, and said in astonishment: "Wang-jie?"

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1. "Little princess" - The original Chinese term is 嬌氣包 (jiāo qì bāo), which literally means "a bundle of delicate temperament/preciousness." It's an affectionate term used to describe someone who is pampered, delicate, and a bit high-maintenance in an endearing way—like a little princess who needs to be doted on. ↩